

MEHEDI ISLAM RAFI

WHERE WATER HOLDS MEMORY

Riverine Landscapes of Bangladesh | Selected Paintings 2026



VISUAL ARTIST • CURATOR • RESEARCHER

rafiart.org

ARTIST STATEMENT

Where Water Holds Memory

My painting practice begins with observing the rivers and everyday landscapes of Bangladesh. Boats, riverbanks, village homes, trees and people at work become a visual language through which I consider memory, belonging and the continuity of rural life.

Watercolour offers me a way to describe atmospheres that are never fixed. Transparent washes, restrained tonal passages and areas of untouched paper allow the paintings to hold both presence and absence. Water is not simply a backdrop: it carries the gestures of labour, travel and community.

In this selected group of riverine landscapes, I draw attention to the often-quiet encounters between human activity and the natural environment. I seek to preserve an emotional sense of place rather than replicate every observed detail.

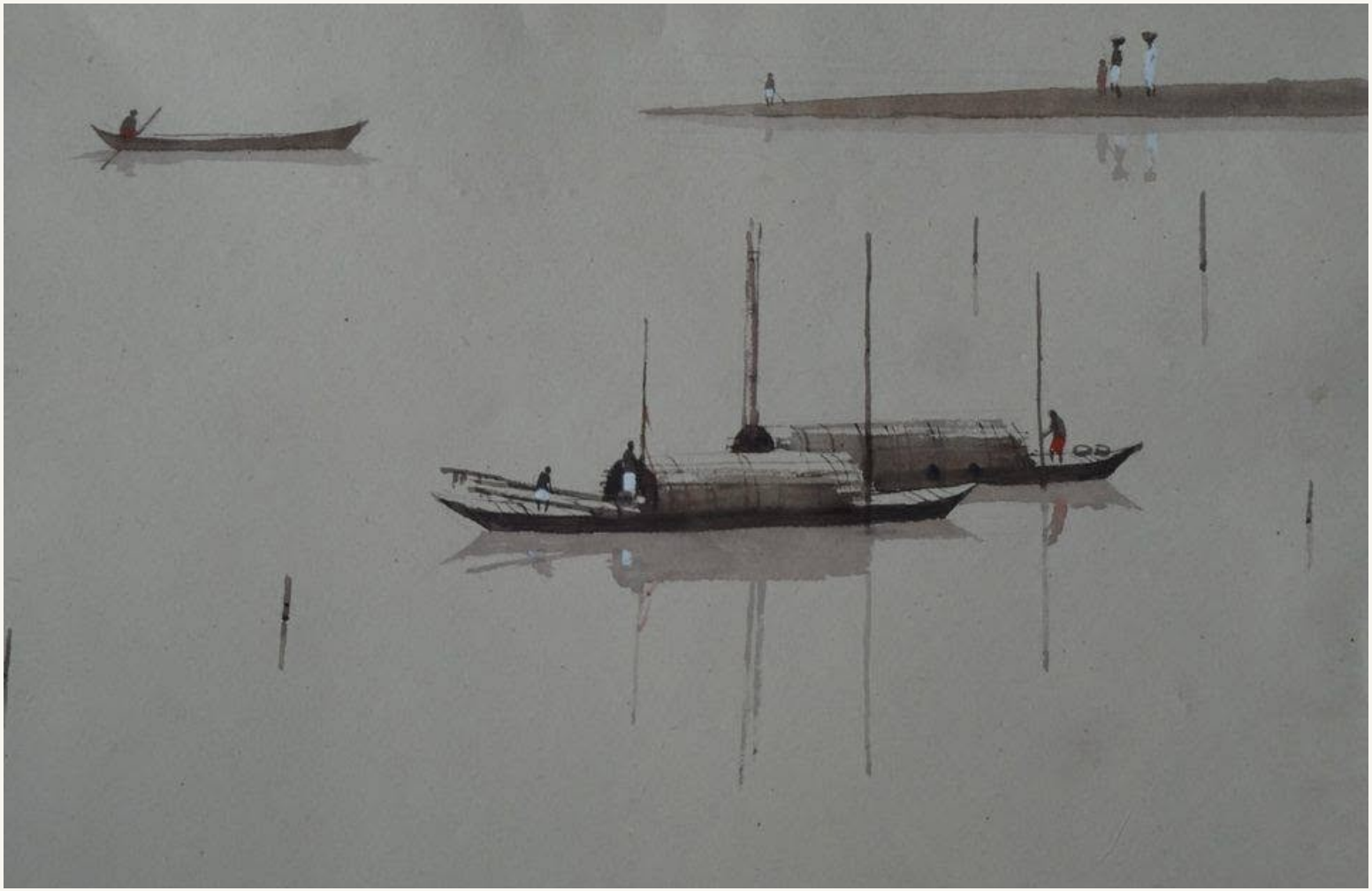
ARTIST PROFILE

Mehedi Islam Rafi

Mehedi Islam Rafi is a Bangladeshi visual artist, curator and researcher based in Dhaka. His art examines river culture, rural life, visual memory and cultural experience, primarily through watercolour and painting.

He is pursuing a PhD in Fine Arts at the University of Dhaka, where he also completed his MFA and BFA. Alongside his studio practice, he works as Assistant Director and Curator at the National Sculpture Gallery, Bangladesh.

His international artistic and curatorial engagements include Nepal Art Expo 2025, Colombo Art Expo 2024, Bali Art Expo 2023 and Yogyakarta Art Expo 2019. He has also undertaken visiting teaching and collaborative activities in Mexico, Sri Lanka and Indonesia.



Silent Passage

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

A study of working boats held in still water, where the quiet rhythm of river travel meets the openness of the landscape.



Golden Riverbank

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

Warm amber tones illuminate a river settlement, tracing the relationship between boats, palm trees, homes and daily labour.



Life Along the River

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

Across an expansive riverbank, travellers and vessels become small but vital marks in a landscape shaped by water.



Reflections of Rural Life

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

Palms, human figures and their reflections establish a delicate balance between habitation and the surrounding river.



Island of Silence

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

A flooded landscape becomes a meditation on fragility, adaptation and the persistence of community.



Floating Homestead

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

Vernacular dwellings and vegetation emerge from a broad expanse of water, suggesting endurance within seasonal change.



Boats Beneath the Palms

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

Traditional covered boats anchor a calm composition of palms, shorelines and layered reflections.



Whispers of the Floodplain

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

With economical brushwork and open paper, the image describes human passage through the quiet floodplain.



Golden Shores

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

An elongated panorama of trees, river craft and people captures the rhythms of settlement beside the water.



The River’s Edge

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

A narrow path leads toward a waterside dwelling, framed by a bare tree and an atmosphere of stillness.



A Quiet Crossing

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

Two palms and a handful of boats punctuate a wide river vista, giving small human gestures room to resonate.



Memories of the Village

2026 | Watercolour on paper | Dimensions: to be confirmed

The clustered forms of village architecture, riverbank and boats evoke a place remembered through atmosphere.

Education & Practice

EDUCATION

PhD in Fine Arts (ongoing); MFA; BFA — University of Dhaka, Bangladesh.

CURATORIAL / PROFESSIONAL

Assistant Director & Curator — National Sculpture Gallery, Bangladesh (2018–present).

SELECTED INTERNATIONAL PROJECTS

Nepal Art Expo (2025); Colombo Art Expo (2024); Bali Art Expo (2023); Yogyakarta Art Expo (2019).

VISITING TEACHING

CETYS University, Mexico (2024); University of the Visual and Performing Arts, Sri Lanka (2024); Universitas Kristen Maranatha, Indonesia (2023).

CONTACT

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Artwork titles are proposed; 2026 dating, medium and physical dimensions require artist confirmation.